Phishing Analysis Case Study: Fake UAE Flag Day AED 200 Gift

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1. Summary

A WhatsApp message circulating ahead of UAE Flag Day claimed that President Sheikh Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan was giving AED 200 to everyone in the UAE. The message included a link and a line saying the sender had "just received" the gift. I analyzed the link safely, without visiting it directly, using urlscan.io, concluded it was a phishing campaign, and reported it to the Abu Dhabi Police and the domain's registrar. The key finding: the domain was registered the day before the campaign, yet urlscan and Google Safe Browsing showed no warning.

Verdict: Phishing / social-engineering scam abusing a national occasion, government figures and telecom brands.

2. How I received it

The message was forwarded to me by a friend, who said she got it from an unknown source. She is the forwarder, not the actor, so her details were not listed as a suspect. This is typical of mass phishing: messages spread through trusted contacts, which lowers people's guard.

3. Method

1. Did not open the link in a browser.
2. Submitted the URL to urlscan.io to get a sandboxed scan, screenshot and network summary.
3. Reviewed the summary, screenshot, page title, IP/ASN data, detected technologies and page statistics, then checked the domain's WHOIS record and pivoted on the main IP.

4. Cross-checked the message text against how real UAE government announcements are made (official channels such as WAM and u.ae).

4. Indicators of compromise (IOCs)

Type	Value
Domain	vjusb[.]buzz
URL	hxxps://vjusb[.]buzz/dqWfbAJEcU/5772&s=wa&t=1793560536&
Registered	31 October 2026 (expires 31 October 2027)
Registrar	Spaceship, Inc. (IANA ID 3862)
Registrant	Hidden behind a privacy service
TLS certificate	Issued 1 November 2026 by WE1, valid 3 months
Main IP (at scan)	104[.]21[.]46[.]181 (Cloudflare)
Other IPs contacted	104[.]16[.]80[.]73, 104[.]16[.]133[.]229, 172[.]67[.]131[.]100
Current DNS A record	188[.]114[.]97[.]3 (Cloudflare)
Page title	"Everyone can receive AED 200 as a special gift to celebrate UAE Flag Day!"
Delivery channel	WhatsApp (URL contains the tag `s=wa`)
Evidence	urlscan.io result

5. Findings

Brand and authority impersonation. The page screenshot shows du and e& logos, a photo of the President and UAE flag imagery, with a single call to action: "Tap here to get it now". Telecom logos have no reason to appear on a government payment.

Very new infrastructure. WHOIS shows the domain was registered on 31 October 2026, one day before my scan, through Spaceship, Inc. with the owner hidden behind a privacy service. urlscan also tagged the page "5h old", which reflects when it was first seen, not

the registration. The TLS certificate (issued by the WE1 CA) was issued on 1 November 2026, the day of the scan. Legitimate government campaigns do not launch on a domain registered a day earlier.

Non-government domain. The site used a `.buzz` domain rather than a `.gov.ae` or `.ae` address.

Cloudflare fronting. All 5 IPs belonged to Cloudflare (AS13335), which hides the real origin server. The scan listed the location as Ascension Island, which is a Cloudflare artifact and says nothing about where the operator is. Cloudflare is cheap and common for phishing kits, and it makes takedown harder. I pivoted on the main IP (104[.]21[.]46[.]181) in urlscan: it is a shared Cloudflare address, and the other scans seen on it looked unrelated, so it does not identify the operator or link this page to other campaigns. Its WHOIS record belongs to Cloudflare, whose abuse contact is abuse@cloudflare.com.

Single-page app. The page was built with Vue.js, so the real destination of the button is loaded by script rather than visible in plain HTML. Page stats: 36 requests, 7 domains, 5 IPs, about 286 kB transferred, 0 cookies.

Timing and social pressure. The scan was on 1 November, two days before Flag Day (3 November). The line "I just received mine!" is a classic fear-of-missing-out hook.

Viral design. The `s=wa` tag in the URL indicates it was built to spread through WhatsApp forwards.

6. Key lesson: "No classification" is not "safe"

urlscan.io returned a verdict of **No classification**, and Google Safe Browsing had not flagged the domain. Taken alone, that could look reassuring. In reality, reputation systems lag behind fresh campaigns by hours or days, and the scammers operate exactly inside that window. The correct conclusion came from the evidence (domain age, certificate date, brand abuse, hosting, the offer itself), not from the absence of a flag.

For SOC work, this means treating an empty verdict on a brand-new domain as "unknown", not "clean".

7. Likely attacker goal (assessment)

I did not visit the destination, so this is an assessment based on typical campaigns of this type, not something I observed. Pages like this usually try to collect Emirates ID details, card numbers or OTPs, or push victims through survey and affiliate chains, and ask them

to share the link to spread it further.

8. Response and reporting

- Did not click or forward the message.
- Filed an incident report through the Abu Dhabi Police portal (Aman service), selecting that no funds were lost, with the link and a summary of findings. The outcome is pending. I will rescan the URL on urlscan.io and record how long it takes to go down.
- Reported the domain to its registrar, Spaceship, at 19:50 UTC on 1 November 2026 and received an automated acknowledgment. Outcome pending.
- Recommended that the friend who forwarded it delete the message, not share it again, and contact her bank if she entered any details.
- Further takedown reports to file: urlscan.io Report button, Google Safe Browsing phishing report, and Cloudflare's abuse form.

9. What I would do next

- Check whether Spaceship (registrar) and Cloudflare have suspended the domain, and record how long it took.
- Review the Redirects, HTTP and Domains tabs in the scan to trace where the button leads.
- Check the DOM and Content tabs for form fields asking for ID, card or OTP data.
- Search urlscan.io and VirusTotal for similar pages using the same URL pattern or page title, to look for related domains in the same campaign.
- Monitor whether Safe Browsing and other feeds eventually flag the domain and note the delay.

10. Takeaways

- Scams ride on national events and trusted figures; check the official channel, not the forward.
- A new domain, a new certificate and brand abuse together are strong signals even when automated tools show nothing.
- Analyze suspicious links in a sandbox, defang IOCs when sharing them, and report to both the authorities and the infrastructure providers.

- Confirm key indicators with a second source. urlscan's "5h old" tag was a first-seen time; WHOIS gave the real registration date, 31 October.
- Shared infrastructure limits attribution. A Cloudflare IP and a privacy-protected WHOIS record did not identify the owner, so the useful actions were reporting to the registrar and the CDN.